

THE KESTREL OF LANTERN- FALL

Fourth Wall Gaming

PRELUDE



There is no ground in this world. There is only the sky, and the wind that fills it, and the people who are born with wings to ride it. They are the Alar — feathered folk, human in the face and body, with a true pair of wings folded from the back. The kestrel-kin are slim and quick; the corvid-kin heavy and black; the condor-kin tall and pale. They do not remember a time before they flew, and they do not imagine a time after.

They live on the spires: enormous pale towers of weathered bone that stand alone in the open air, the husks of sky-leviathans dead so long that no one living has seen one move. The Alar hollowed out those bones and made homes in them, ring above ring, and hung the spires with thousands of small oil-lamps tended at dusk and dawn along the bone walkways. Between the spires run the lanes — roads of moving air, the living wind that carries everyone everywhere, that brings the trade and the news and the wandering shoals of small sky-creatures the people hunt. The wind is the sea, the road, and the breath of the world all at once.

And the wind is dying.

It is called the Stilling. In places the air simply stops — goes flat and dead and silent, with no breath in it at all and no lift for a wing. These still zones open like sores, out along the old lanes and under the spires, and season by season they spread, and no one knows how to close them. Worse than the dead air are the people it takes. An Alar caught too long in a Stilling goes *Hushed*: they fall silent, and then

soundless, and then a stillness begins to come off them like cold off ice, and what is left walks and looks at you with nothing behind its eyes. No one knows how to bring them back, either.

Against all of this stand the Gale Wardens — rangers and rescue-fliers who chart the dying lanes, pull the living out of the dead air, and keep watch on the spreading quiet.

One of them is Sefa Rocksquill. She is Vael, kestrel-kin, but she was born too big and too heavy-feathered for a kestrel — built like something that has no business flying as well as she does — and she never fit the courier-rafts of the Moults, the raft-nation of her people. The Moults have lost lanes to the Stilling, and kin with them. So Sefa carries the hatred of the dead wind the way a sailor hates the calm that starves him, and she found the one place in the sky where being heavy is a virtue: the Wardens' lances, who fight in a single hard diving pass and end a thing before it can end them.

This is the record of one of her nights, at the spire called Lanternfall, where the lamps are lit against a dark that is only getting wider.

CHAPTER ONE — THE NINTH NIGHT



The lamps of Lanternfall were coming up along the western face when Sefa Rocksquill saw the haze fold.

She was flying the fourth ring on lamp-patrol, bored, watching the tenders move their small fires wick to wick, and out in the eastern haze the air bunched and folded the way it does around something large that does not want to be seen. A drake. Riding the dead currents in off the empty east, low and slow, and it had not seen her.

She did what her wings were built for. She folded them and fell out of the high amber with the wingspear couched, and she drove the point down through the root of its left wing before it knew the sky held anything but itself. The drake screamed. It tore loose and tumbled and hit the lamp-ring scaffold twelve metres down and smashed its other wing on the bone.

She came down after it. Her hatchet rang off its skull and did nothing she could feel. She set her boot against its neck and hauled on the spear and the spear would not come. She hauled again, harder, and it still would not come — and then the jaws closed on her left arm and the pain went white to the shoulder.



The drake held. It got its weight under it and threw itself over the rim to take her down by the arm into the deep sky, and for a long moment the whole drop pulled at her through the bone of her own arm. She braced and wrenched with everything she had. The grip broke. The wing-skin tore off her spear-point and the drake fell away alone, turning, getting small, gone into the haze it had come out of. She kept the spear. She always kept the spear.

The lamp-tenders had seen it and they called for Wardens, and two came, and the medic cut the blood-stiff harness off her arm and pressed a dressing flat against the bite.

“A drake doesn’t choose its ground,” he said. “It goes where the wind packs the prey.” He worked while he talked. “This one was thin under the hide. Third eastern stray this month. It wasn’t hunting here because here is good. It was hunting here because the east is empty. Starving things come to the light.” He looked up at her. “You did it a kindness.”

An old Vael on the scaffold, soot to her elbows, said it to no one. “The east haze used to sing with skimmers at dusk. Been quiet since the thaw.”

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Esk Veil-Torn drafted fliers, not invalids, and she said so.

Sefa made her report at the roost-hall with the arm splinted to her ribs — the kill, the medic’s reading of it, the empty eastern lanes. The commander stood at the survey table with the eastern charts already pinned and already flagged with dead air, and she heard it out.

“Good kill. Clean dive, the lamp-tenders say.” She did not look up from the charts. “Stupid to stand on it pulling at the spear with the thing still alive. You’ll learn.” She moved a flag a finger’s width east. “Something the size of a drake found nothing to eat across forty kilometres of lane. That’s not thinning. That’s dead.”

She offered three days’ rest or the dawn launch, and the honesty to choose between them. “I draft fliers, not invalids, so tell me honestly which you are.”

“Sooner is better,” Sefa said. “Wouldn’t you say, commander.”

So Esk put her and Kithrel of the Moults on the survey line east at next light, dead-air readings every five kilometres, with one order over the rest. “You are not to fight anything you can outfly. One drake on the lamp-rings is an incident. A Warden pair lost in the dead lanes is a hole in my muster.” She signed a quartermaster chit for instruments and flares and three days’ rations, sent her to the surgeon that night, and told her to put the near-fatal grip in her own account, in her own hand. “Vanity kills more fliers than drakes do.”

The surgeon was a square woman named Veka who took the field-dressing off, looked at the bite, and redid it properly with the arm splinted wing-safe. “You tear my stitches doing something brave,” Veka said, “I’ll sew the arm to your ribs.”

At the mess Sefa asked about Kithrel of the Moults, and the company told her in pieces. Fastest survey-flier on the muster — she’ll be at the shallows while you’re still finding the lane. A Greywake survivor, off-shift the day the spire sank, who wore eleven lane-tokens braided into her primaries for a flight that did not come back. *Don’t touch the braids. Don’t ask. She’ll tell you or she won’t.* And she volunteered for every new Stilling survey and charted the dead-air margins tighter than the regulations allowed.

“She’s not measuring the still air,” one of them said. “She’s daring it.”

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At next light Sefa drew her kit and met Kithrel on the eastern launch ledge. Kithrel set the terms the way she set everything, flat and exact.

“Out to the Veyl shallows along the old east lane. I read the air, you watch the sky. When I say we turn, we turn. The edge doesn’t negotiate.”

“I’ll try to keep up,” Sefa said, and let her lead.

They flew east, and the wind died around them by degrees, the lift going slack under the wing the way a current goes slack. Fifteen kilometres out, where the lane should have been loud with skim-shoals at the turn of the morning, Sefa saw pale shapes standing on a skim-reef in the haze and could not make them out. Kithrel looked once, and something went out of her voice.

“Nine years on this lane. That is none of them.”

They came in high and offset, on terms — first gust of anything wrong, climb and run west — and at four hundred metres Kithrel read the aneroid and stopped reading a number at all.

“Zero. Not low. Zero. There is no breath in this air at all.” She held the dial where Sefa could see it. “The still zone isn’t out at the shallows. It’s here.”

On the reef stood nine figures in wax-bleached robes, evenly spaced, facing east, singing low and together. None of them turned. The air around them was wrong, flat and dead, and drifting between them were pale bells the size of a crouching man, slow, going from singer to singer, settling over the upturned faces and drinking.



They pulled back to a reef-knuckle a kilometre and a half west of the zero line and set a picket behind the bone-spine with the light at their backs, because dead air is one-way ground. They watched, and they talked it through low. The robes were unmarked on purpose, Sefa said — nine matched vestments meant a cell with a wax-house behind it, not strays who wandered in. Kithrel knew the doctrine from her diver days: a stillwight strikes for the head, a thrust passes through it and a wide cutting edge bites, and the things hunt by sensing breath — which was why moving air, west of the zero line, hid the two of them. The Choir went from nine voices to seven. The bells went from seven to nine.

“Head home,” Sefa said, when she had seen enough to know the rest. “We don’t need to count them to know what’s going to happen. Next we find the ones who sent these fools out here to die. Fly quiet and fly safe.”

They flew the wind-gradient on the way back, Kithrel calling the readings — living wind down to absolute zero, the skin of the zone mapped — and somewhere over the last living lane she said it without looking across. “You watched the thing that kills me in my sleep, and you watched me, both at once. Esk drafted well.”

At the roost-hall Sefa laid all of it before Esk. The zero reading. The reef. Nine matched vestments. Seven bells becoming nine. The commander did not call it worship.

“Walkers wander in alone. Nine, in matched wax, in formation, on a schedule, at a reef that happens to sit on a Warden survey line — that’s not worship. That’s logistics. Someone provisioned that.” She looked at the charts. “And someone, somewhere west of that zone, is already sewing the next nine.”

She sent them into the city to find which wax-house had dressed nine bodies for the east, and to start from the lane-shrine where a Hushed lampwright had been driven off in the spring.

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The city work went badly at first and then well.

Sefa’s canvass died on the doorstep — her drake story had run ahead of her, the order books shut, a watcher-boy went off his perch and did not come back. Then an old gantry friend named Halla Pitchwick gave her the thread for the price of remembering her name. Orrim’s Pale-Vats had run night-shift white work at scale in early spring. The foreman, not the master, had taken the order — from a soft-spoken hooded Vael who smelled of shrine-incense and paid over the odds without haggling. Nine bundles had gone down, portered toward the condemned bone-galleries under the windlane approach.

Kithrel worked the shrine end and came back with the rest. The beggars knew of a quiet supper — robed folk, candles, every ninth night, in the sealed galleries under the approach. The next was the next night. A cantor at the shrine had asked her twice who she flew for.

“Silence bought with coin re-sells to fear at a discount,” Kithrel said, when they put the two halves together. “And the moment we let go of the foreman, he re-sells the leaning.”

They agreed the order of it. Esk that night. The galleries before dawn. The foreman last, timed so he could not warn the supper. “You’re a better pathfinder than I am,” Sefa told her, and meant it.

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Esk heard the converged threads in the night chart room and stood a while with her hands flat on the map.

“They’re gathering in the bones of my own spire,” she said. “Forty metres under my launch ledge.” She approved the plan with three changes. The foreman would be squeezed under a signed writ, because a paid silence cracks faster when refusing is a crime. The supper would be watched, not raided. “I want the client. Spring a raid and I get nine more fools while the tailor walks. Bring me a face.” And a rescue wing would stand at the launch ledge from dusk on flare-watch. “A flare under the spire means the quiet game is already lost.”

For the gallery scout she gave one standing order, no judgment clause. “Take the aneroid. If it flutters toward zero in a closed bone hall, you walk out.”

Then Sefa asked the question that decided what she carried. “Is this spear work or sword work? I’d like something I could use against a stillwight, should the need arise.”

Esk confirmed the diver doctrine — a thrust passes through the thing and a wide cutting edge bites — and took a Warden falchion down off the chart-room rack and put it in her hand. Heavy, single-edged, old. “Bring it back with a story or don’t bother bringing it back.”

Sefa took it with a quiet Kestrel-kin prayer. She drew a throwing hatchet for the close dark and racked her wingspear against the wall as too long for the corridors of the dead.

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They went down before dawn, the first time, only to look.

Kithrel led, no lamps, blades sooted so they would throw no shine. The galleries opened ahead of them in the grey vent-light, and there was a path swept clean down the middle of them — the sign of regular feet. Kithrel chalked the side-mouths low on the bone as they passed and did not enter any of them. The main line was the job.

It brought them to the supper room: an old Marrower tapping-chamber, twenty metres across, eight or nine mats laid in a half-circle

facing a far archway like pews facing a pulpit. Cold tallow stubs. Fresh bread. New mooring rope. Water-jugs stacked against the near wall, provisioned from above and recently.

“Supper room,” Kithrel breathed. “Empty. For now.”

The far arch hung with a heavy felt curtain, and Sefa learned nothing through it. Kithrel crouched at the gap, a finger on the floor, and read what Sefa could not.

“Hem’s weighted. Bone beads, sewn in, so it never swings, never whispers.” She drew her breath at the gap. “And smell low. Burnt wick. Tallow-smoke, cold but not old.” She sat back. “Supper’s tomorrow. So who needed a lamp tonight?”

“Ain’t no use getting caught tonight,” Sefa said. “Do we have what we need for now?”

“One look up the vault on the way out. Then home before the dawn shift wakes the under-stair. That’s my asking price.”

While Kithrel found a perch in the vault, the curtain lifted, and a woman came through it. Vael, flat-feathered, a burn-scar on the web of one thumb, an unlit hand-lamp in her grip. She went down the half-circle of mats straightening them, and touched each jug once in a count, and went back through the curtain without a sound. Sefa pressed into a side-mouth and was not seen. Both of them put the face away to keep. On the way out her harness buckle rocked a jug a finger’s width out of its dust-ring, and she could not set it right without making it worse, and she left it.

They came up before the dawn shift and took it to Esk.

Sefa gave her the room — the mats, the curtained arch, the provisions from above — and then the keeper, in detail. “Vael woman. Burn-scar on the web of one thumb. Her eyes moved, commander. Nothing behind them did.”

“Burn-scar. Left thumb or right?”

“Left.”

“Wren Sallowmend.” Esk set the name down like a weight. “Lampwright, eastern face, twenty-two years on the wicks. Went silent in spring. She didn’t walk into a still zone. Somebody collected her. They’re keeping her like a sexton.” She looked at the map. “The cult doesn’t just worship what the Stilling makes. They house it.”

She named the supplier — Bele Tarrow, foreman of the rendering floor at the Pale-Vats — and set the quiet approach. Sefa would catch him alone, between the bells, at a counter-house called the Tallow Cup, with the writ in her pocket and not on the table.

“Quiet,” Sefa said. “Commander. When things get loud, I tend to break stuff.”

Esk almost smiled. And on the keeper she gave one last order. “If it comes to it down there, break what you have to. But if it can be left standing, leave it standing. She was one of ours first.”

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The foreman’s name was Bele Tarrow, and Sefa went to him with her hands empty.

She found him at the Tallow Cup between the first bell and the second — a big Roak gone soft in the shoulders, grey at the crest, sitting with his back to the wall and his eye on the door, guarding a bowl he was not eating. There was a child’s tally-bead bracelet on his wrist, old and worn smooth, and he touched it without knowing he did. Kithrel watched the door from across the lane.

She had the charter in her pocket. She left it there and took the stool beside him.

“You heard about the drake this week?”

“You’re the Rocksquill,” he said. “The Kestrel.”

She let the silence sit and looked at him, and what she read was a frightened man, not a paid one — the fear coming up from below the stair and not down from the guild — and grief already in him for something he had not lost yet.

“Is everyone okay?” she said, gentle. “Anything I could help you with, Bele Tarrow?”

He came apart then, quietly, the way big men do. His girl. Derra, a vat-clerk on his own floor, the best tally-hand in the works. Gone quiet at Winterend, then no sound, then the air going soft around her like wool over the world. A soft-spoken Vael with clean hands had found him at shift’s end, and he gave back the words the way you give back a knot that holds your life.

“He said, ‘The silence is not a sickness, foreman. It is an arrival. She will be honored among us, and you may pay her keeping like any loving father pays a dowry.’”

So he paid. Bread and water-jugs and mooring rope, every ninth night, off his own tally, left at the third side-mouth past the under-stair. He had seen her once, at Solstice, let to stand at a curtain and watch her straighten the mats.

“She looked kept,” he said. “That’s all I can say. Kept.”

Nine days ago the asking had changed. Rope in quantity. And lamp-oil — four casks, and four more tonight.

“They sit in the dark down there,” Tarrow said. “They love the dark. So what does a congregation that doesn’t light lamps want with that much oil?”

“Those people who say they’re tending people with the stillness,” Sefa said, “they’re tending the stillness itself.”

He nodded slow, like she had named a thing he had carried alone a long time. “I know. I knew when they asked for the rope. You don’t need rope to tend the sick.”

The soft man gave the orders, he said. A woman with a cantor’s lilt and a big quiet one did what he said. Three ninth-nights back the soft man had worn a new pin at his collar — small worked bone, the shape of a closed hand. A rendering man knows worked bone. Featherwright craft. The guild whose oath was *no one falls*.

He rose for his shift at the second bell. At the door he turned back, and gave her the only thing he had.

“My girl, Warden. Whatever you’re doing down there. My girl.”

CHAPTER TWO — THE LAST SUPPER



They went down again that night, the second time, to watch — and split at the gallery mouth. Kithrel stayed there in the shadow with three flares and Esk's runner. Sefa went up the north scaffold into the vault of the supper-room on half-furled wings — dead air bites only half of nothing, and shoves the other half about the room like a held breath let go — and folded onto the high perch and became part of the bone.

The room woke beneath her. The keeper came first and lit the tallow down the half-circle of mats, and the chamber went amber, and the shadows climbed the vault toward Sefa. Then six families filed in and took the mats like mourners taking pews. Then the Hushed, led not driven, seven of them, the tallow-flames leaning and guttering as the dead air came in with them. Among them was a small woman with ink worn into the webbing of her fingers, her eyes open and moving and nothing behind them. Derra Tarrow.

Then three came through the felt arch. A big silent Ossuin who took post by the casks. A woman in grey with an ash-censer swinging in her hand. And between them, unhurried, a soft-faced Vael with clean hands and a small closed hand of bone at his collar. Vesh.

He lifted his empty hands to the mats and spoke in a warm, carrying voice.

“Friends. You’ve fed them faithfully, and they’ve grown. Tonight they’re ready to give back what the world gave them — and you’ll have your beloveds returned to the air they came from. All of you. Tonight is the last supper. After this, no one need pay again.”

The big man laid his hand on an oil-cask.

Sefa’s hatchet was already turning in her fingers. She threw it. It went out of the high dark and into the wrist on the cask, and the oil choked off, and every amber-lit face in the room tipped up toward a perch that had held nothing a heartbeat before.

Vesh had a spark-striker in his clean hand over the spilled oil. He did not crank it.

“A Warden. Of course.” His thumb rested on the wheel. “Come down, feather. You don’t want to be up there when this room goes to sleep. There’s no flying in dead air. And there’s no flying at all once I turn my wrist.”

She rose to her height and rang the falchion out of its sheath for them all to see and threw her voice down. “You’re surrounded, surgeon. The whole draft’s in these galleries.”



“No,” he said, almost kind. “There are no other wings. I’d have heard them. This air carries a lie better than it carries a flock.”

But the families had heard her name the casks. The grey-crested Lanhawk man came up off his mat. “Vesh. He said it was a blessing. He said our daughter would only—”

Vesh sent the big man to the arch and kept the striker, and Sefa stopped wasting breath on him.

“To the flares!” she shouted, the whole launch-deck of her lungs behind it. “Go! The wing’s at the door!”

The families broke for the mouth. Kithrel’s flare went up red and hung, and her voice came thin across the room. “Here! Eyes on the light — move!”

Sefa folded her wings and dropped. Nine metres, straight down, the falchion out front, the dive she was born for — and the dead air took it. Her wings found their half of nothing at the bottom and the dive came wrong and the falchion opened on empty, and Vesh simply leaned a hand’s-width aside as she fell past his shoulder. She wrenched it back with the last thing she had, and the blade — the wide cutting edge Esk had put in her hand — came down through the root of his left wing and did not stop. The wing came away. He folded to the floor, and the pin winked once in the tallow-light.

His thumb finished its work on the way down.

The room took a breath of fire. It ran out from where he fell in two bright tongues, one along the swept path toward the mats and one curling back toward the casks, and the dead air did nothing to it but sit there and let it climb. Heat slapped her across the face. The Hushed pulled back from the light, rooted and shuddering.

She took up the dying man to carry him out — the face Esk wanted — and then the first cask began to sing, that rising kettle-shriek of oil going to vapour, and she knew it the way every Warden knows it. She rammed his body into the cask and threw herself the other way, for the girl. The cask burst. It picked her up and threw her and the fire caught in the feathers of her left wing.

She came down at Derra’s feet, and the fire on her wing went small. In the dead hush that wrapped the silent girl the flames starved and

ducked — and her own breath went thin and flat in her chest, the air giving nothing back.

She could not fly. She gathered the girl against her and held what breath she had and ran for the mouth. Fifteen metres of fire toward a red star. She made ten of them. Then the held breath turned to a fist in her chest and her legs stopped believing in the floor, and she went down five metres short, the dark closing in from every edge.

She did not take the rope for herself. She looped it around Derra and shoved the girl the last terrible distance toward Kithrel.

“Got her — I’ve got her!”

The hush went out of the room on the rope with the girl, and the fire remembered Sefa was there, and the dark won and took her down into it.

Kithrel dropped the line and came back into the fire for her and dragged her clear as a second cask blew.

She woke on the cold bone of the gallery floor, real air sawing into her lungs, the sweetest thing she had ever breathed. Kithrel had two fists in her harness.

“There she is. There she is, you stubborn squill. I went in for you. Cask went off behind us — you owe me a drink.”

Sefa sat up and looked at her wing. The feathers were burned to black quills, the membrane stiff, the whole of it hanging wrong. She looked at it a long time. Then she looked at Kithrel.

“Fuck,” she said.

“Yeah,” Kithrel said. “That about covers it.”

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The fire had its own wind now — a hot, wrong updraught where there should have been none, sucking the smoke up the dead-air shaft she had climbed an hour ago. And the cold of the gallery-mouth stone under her was the only kind thing in the room. Her left wing would not answer. She did not look at it again. She already knew.

Down the throat of the under-stair, jammed into the dark where the smoke still thinned, the rescued were a knot of shapes. Six families. The girl among them, ink-fingered and still, her scorched wing held off her body like a broken fan, sitting the way the Hushed sit. Esk's rescue-line still looped under the girl's arms. The smoke was coming down the ceiling toward all of them in a slow grey tide.

"Can you carry me as far as the stair," Sefa said.

Kithrel didn't argue it. She got a shoulder under the good wing and levered her up off the stone, and the room tilted and came level, and the legs held. They were the one part of her the fire hadn't taken. The two of them made one limping animal, the ruined wing trailing, Kithrel's breath sawing in her ear.

She turned it into orders, because orders are what hold a frightened flock together. "On me. All of you — on the Warden. Up the stair, hands on the wall, don't run." They peeled off the dark and started to move, herding their own. The girl rose when the others rose, that terrible Hushed obedience, and let the rope lead her. It was working. They were moving, two metres at a time, ahead of the smoke.

And then the grey-crested man stopped.

He turned back — not up the stair, *back*, toward the felt arch and the orange roar behind it, toward the place a name he kept saying had gone into the fire. "She's still in there," he said, to no one, to the flames. "My — she's still—" and he took a step toward the heat, against the whole current of everyone else. Someone grabbed his sleeve and missed. Four metres from her. The fire four metres past him. Behind her the line wavered — one man breaking ranks can unmake the whole of it.

She had a half-second and two legs that wouldn't carry her to him in time. So she used the only thing that was faster than walking.

The curse came first, short and ugly and aimed past him at the thing in the fire — *you will not have him too* — and the command came on its heels, the Warden's voice, the one that does not ask. It came a heartbeat late. On any other night it would have nailed his feet to

the floor the instant it left her. This night his daughter was in a fire and grief is louder than rank, and he flinched at it and half-turned and kept going anyway.

She found the word again. Threw it harder. *Harl*. His name and the order behind it, all the launch-deck she had left.

It landed.

He stopped, one stride short of the heat, the air peeling in front of his face. His shoulders came down. The fight went out of him all at once and he sagged, and the man beside him got a fist in his sleeve that held this time. “Come on, Harl. Come on. The Warden says up. We go up.” Whatever had been in her voice, they had decided to believe it. The line knitted shut behind her.

“Nice,” Kithrel breathed against her ear, hauling her on. “Do that again if anyone else gets clever.”

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So they went up. Slow, the smoke at their heels, the ruined wing dragging the stair behind her like a broken sail. A Warden and her partner making one animal, six families and a silent girl strung along the wall with their hands on the cold bone. The supper room fell away below into its own light. The stair bent, and bent again, and the air began to taste of *night* instead of oil —

— and that was when she heard them. Above, on the windlane approach: the double-beat of working wings, a lot of them, and a voice she knew carving down through the dark.

“*LANTERNFALL DRAFT — CALL OFF, who’s down there!*” Esk’s voice, and behind it the wink of a warden lantern swinging into the gallery throat, and the relief of a dozen wings finally answering Kithrel’s flare.

Sefa tapped Kithrel’s shoulder twice — the old courier signal, *your call* — and let her hand drop. Kithrel got it. She always got it.

“*Gallery mouth — Kithrel of the Moul!*” she shouted up the throat, and her voice had the carry Sefa’s used to before tonight. “*Six families*

and one Hushed, all walking, all out! Cult leader's dead — burned with the room! Fire's below us and spreading — we need medics and we need the stair cleared! And send someone for the Rocksquill, she's down a wing and she's done!"

A pause. Then Esk's voice came back flat and fast: "*Understood. Hold the mouth. Wing's coming to you.*" Lanternlight swung, and the first wardens dropped into the throat in a clatter of pinions — a medic among them, a stretcher-sling, two more peeling toward the families with water and steady hands. The grey-crested man let himself be led. The girl went unresisting into a warden's care, ink-fingers and all, and somewhere far back in Sefa's skull a thought filed itself for later — *her father, he needs to know she's out* — and not now. Now was for later.

Now she swore.

She picked a good one — long, heartfelt, anatomically ambitious, the kind her old wing-sergeant would have docked her pay for — and she folded down onto the cold stone of the stair with her back against the bone wall and her ruined wing trailing across the step, and she stopped holding herself up. Kithrel slid down next to her, shoulder to shoulder, both of them filthy and smoking faintly. Above, the draft did the work now. Below, the fire ate the place where a soft-voiced man had tried to put a whole congregation to sleep.

"You're buying the drinks," Kithrel said.

"I'm buying the drinks," Sefa agreed.

CHAPTER THREE — THE CLOSED HAND



She woke to the smell of clean wax and crushed feverbalm, which was a better smell than the one she had gone to sleep in. White light. A high domed room of pale bone, scrubbed and lime-washed, tall slot-windows letting the morning gales sing through gauze. She was face-down on a padded surgeon's cradle, arms strapped loose to the rests, and her ruined left wing was spread out to the side on a board, pinned open under a frame of little hooks so it could not move while it was worked. She could not feel it. There was a numbing draught in her, her tongue thick with it, and a warm distant tugging where she knew the pain ought to be.

A voice above and behind her shoulder, dry and unhurried. "Awake. Good. I prefer them awake — a wing tells me more when its owner can flinch."

The surgeon came round into sight as she circled the board: an old Roak woman, broad and stooped, hands gloved in waxed kidskin already pink at the fingertips with Sefa's blood, a jeweller's loupe strapped over one eye. Her apron was Featherwright grey. And at her throat, on a plain cord, was a small worked-bone pin — a closed hand. The same craft, the same mark Sefa had last seen on Vesh, two breaths before she took his wing off and the room went up.

The surgeon followed her eyes to it without looking up from her work. "You're staring at my pin. They all do, this week. Word travels."

A small, careful tug at something deep in the wing-root; the warmth shifted. “So let’s have it plain before I’ve got your flight-tendon in my fingers, because I don’t work over a patient who thinks I’m the enemy. Yes. I am Featherwright. Yes, I knew Vesh — I trained the hands that burned in your fire. And yes, I took the Fallen Fund’s coin to put a Warden’s wing back together this morning.” The loupe-eye swivelled to fix her, huge and wet. “Now. Ask me what you came up wanting to ask. I’ll answer with my mouth while my hands keep working. I find that’s the honest way.”

Face-down, strapped, drooling numbing-draught, Sefa took the only shot she had.

“Ser. I’ll be honest with you. You’re the second Featherwright wing-surgeon I’ve been this close to in two days.” A beat. “The first one I had to take apart. So forgive me if my standards have come down. You’ve already got me beat — you’ve had your hands in my back for an hour and you haven’t once tried to set the room on fire.”

The tugging in her wing paused. Then the old woman made a sound Sefa didn’t expect — a short, dry bark of a laugh, gravel rolled in a cup. “Hah. ‘Standards come down.’ Good. They should.” A hook clicked. “And you’re not wrong to keep score. But you can stop watching my pin like it’s going to bite. If I wanted you dead I’d not be sweating over your flight-tendon on a Fund chit that doesn’t cover my candle-oil. I’d have closed you crooked and let the air do the rest.” She said it as mildly as weather. “The name’s Brede. Wing-Master Ossla Brede.”

“What was he like,” Sefa said. “Vesh. Any thought on why he went to the stillness.”

Brede threaded something fine through the wing-root — Sefa felt the whisper of it, a thin bright wire that made her good wing twitch against its strap — and tied it off before she spoke.

“Gentle. That’s the thing nobody believes after, but he was. Quiet hands, quiet voice, remembered the names of every patient’s children. The apprentices loved him. *I* loved him, the way you love the best thing you ever made.” A clamp clicked. “And underneath it, nothing. No floor. Most of us patch a wing because we can’t stand to watch a

creature grounded — it hurts us, so we fix it. Vesh fixed wings the way you'd square a crooked shelf. Tidy. Correct. He never felt the patient at all. Then a moult-sick fledgling came in — wings come in wrong, a year of hard surgery ahead of her and maybe flight at the end, maybe not — and Vesh looked at all that striving and decided the kind thing, the clean thing, was to stop it. Stop her."

The loupe-eye came up. "That's your answer, if you want my thought. The Choir didn't turn him. The Choir gave him *words* for what was already sitting where his heart should have been. You've heard them preach — the world is sick with trying, the gales and the flying and the clawing to stay aloft all suffering, and the Stilling is the world being allowed to rest. Set down the wing. To a man who never once felt the joy of the thing, who only saw flight as a problem he was paid to correct, that's not madness. It's the first idea that ever made him feel like he was right." She made a small contemptuous noise. "Far worse than madness. A madman you can pity. Vesh was *comforted*."

She straightened, pressed the small of her own stooped back. "You want to know what frightens me. It's a good sermon. I've buried a husband and three apprentices to bad seasons, and on the worst nights I can hear why someone tired enough would want to walk into the quiet and stop. Vesh wasn't a monster who tricked the desperate. He was a desperate man who believed the comfort. There'll be more of him. There's always more tired people than there are reasons to keep flapping."

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"Hell," Sefa said into the padding. "I'll take a little discomfort and reality over comfort and muffled silence every day. Is that all it is, though? Get people to lie down in a soft bed, and that's all you need to make them watch the ones they love burn? Fuck that." A beat. "... Pardon me. Sorry."

Brede snorted. "I've had my hands inside Wardens for forty years, girl, I've heard every word there is and invented a few." She waved the curse off with two bloody fingers. But the rest of it landed somewhere

and stayed. “‘Discomfort and reality over comfort and silence.’ Aye. That’s the whole argument against the Choir in a mouthful, and it took a kestrel face-down on my table to say it plain.” Quieter, then, the thing under the thing. “You’re right to be sick over how cheap it is. A soft bed and a kind voice and a name for your tiredness. That’s all the closed hand needs.”

The closed hand. She had not said *Vesh* that time. She had said the guild.

So Sefa went for it — not as a Warden working an asset, but straight. *This matters. You’re already on the right side of it. Help us.* Brede’s hands slowed. Her face closed a notch — not hostile, careful, the look of a woman doing sums she didn’t like. Because what was really being asked was for a Featherwright to inform on Featherwrights, and she had forty years and a guild-pension riding on that grey apron.

“...You’re not just making conversation,” she said. “You’re recruiting me.”

For a long moment the only sound was the gulls and the gauze. Then she set down her hook, peeled the loupe off her eye, and looked at Sefa properly for the first time. “Forty years I’ve kept my head down and my hands clean. Patched whoever the Fund sent, asked no questions, took no sides. And I’m too old and too tired to watch the thing I gave my life to turn into a machine for talking sad people into dying.” She exhaled, long. “So. Yes. On my terms — I’m no one’s bird on a string, and I’ll not be skulking or wearing a wire to guild-hall. But I’ll talk to your commander. The real one, Veil-Torn. And I’ll tell her what I’ll tell you now, as earnest of it.”

She tapped the closed hand at her throat. “This isn’t guild issue. Most Featherwrights never see one. It marks an old fellowship inside the guild — the Stillhand. Hundreds of years back it was a *kindness*: the surgeons who sat with the dying, who’d ease a hopeless case out clean when the alternative was a month of screaming. Mercy that meant what the word means. I took my pin at thirty, and I’ve eased more good deaths than I can count, and I’ll not apologise for one.” Her jaw tightened. “But the Choir’s been whispering in the Stillhand’s

ear a long while. Some of the younger ones don't say 'ease the dying' anymore. They say 'ease the suffering,' and they've decided everyone's suffering, and the whole world's a hopeless case. Vesh wore this pin. So do four or five others I could name who'd have called what he did beautiful. And so do I — because somebody who remembers what it meant needs to still be in the room when they vote."

Sefa couldn't reach her sword — it was somewhere across the room and her arms were strapped — so she did the only thing she could, which was say it, and mean it.

"Wing-Master. What you just did took more nerve than anything I did in that fire." She waited until the loupe-eye lifted. "You've got a Warden's word. Mine. Whatever the Stillhand is when this is over — whoever doesn't like that you opened the door — they come through me first. I can't lift a wing right now, but I can still lift a wingspear. My sword's yours, ser. That's not Warden manners. That's a debt."

Brede held her eye a long beat, and then she did the gruff thing, because surgeons don't know how to be thanked. "Hmf. A grounded kestrel and a tired old butcher. The Stillhand must be quaking." But her voice had gone thick, and she busied her hands with a clamp that didn't need adjusting, and only half-managed the joke before she muttered, almost too low to catch, "...It's been a while since anyone offered to stand between me and anything."

Then she was back to business, where she was safe. "Now. You'll not fly for a week, and you'll not trust that wing in a real gale for two. Push it before then and you'll undo my morning and your own sky both. So whatever you're scheming, you do it sitting down."

Which solved the problem, when Sefa thought about it. Brede couldn't be seen walking into a Warden hall — but there was nothing in the world more ordinary than a company-commander coming to a quiet surgery to sit at the bedside of the Warden who'd burned a wing off saving six families. The meet didn't need a back alley. It needed Esk to visit her wounded. Cover that was true.

The fastest, most trustworthy pair of wings she knew was almost certainly downstairs, pacing a hole in the landing and refusing to go home until someone told her Sefa had woken. Brede cracked the door and barked it down the stair-throat, and there were boots before she'd finished.

Kithrel came through fast, soot still in the seams of her, eyes going to the pinned-open wing and back to Sefa's face. "There she is." The relief cracked her voice; she covered it with a scowl, shut the door with her heel, dropped low. "What. What's happened."

So Sefa told her. All of it, not coy — Vesh and what he was, the closed-hand pin, the Stillhand gone rotten, Brede turned to their side, the names she held, the plan: Esk comes here, to visit her wounded Warden, and the meet wears that for a coat. Kithrel listened with her jaw getting harder, glanced once at Brede, who lifted two bloody fingers in a dry salute, and breathed out slow. "Saints. A night off and you start a war with a guild."

Then, lower, while she leaned in like she was just fussing the blanket: *Get me a knife. Something small. Where I can reach it.* Her hands didn't pause — she'd smuggled worse than steel — and a moment later there was a cold familiar weight tucked along Sefa's good forearm under the blanket, hilt to her fingers. "For a surgery full of healers," Kithrel murmured, "you're awfully sure someone in here wants you opened the wrong way."

Which was exactly the thought Sefa couldn't put down. Brede had named *four or five others*. And a Featherwright surgery was full of Featherwright hands. So while Kithrel straightened, she stopped bantering and *looked* — the survey-flier's slow sweep, reading the room for the one thing that didn't sit right.

The brazier-boy: nothing. The hand moving gauze in the next room: a wedding-tune, oblivious. Brede: Brede. And then the apprentice at the long instrument-table. Vael, young, maybe seventeen, narrow shoulders — and she had been laying out the same tray of hooks for the length of the whole conversation. Set them, squared them, lifted them, set them again. Angled wrong, too: not at her table

but a quarter-turn toward the cradle, the ear forward. And when Sefa had said the word *Stillhand*, the girl's hands had stopped. Just for a breath. Then started again, too smooth. She turned to rack a clamp and her collar gapped, and there it was — a small worked-bone glint on a cord at her throat. A closed hand.

But the look gave Sefa the thing worth the looking: the girl wasn't coiled. She was *terrified*. White at the knuckle, breath too shallow, eyes fixed hard on her tray so she wouldn't find Sefa watching. Not an assassin. A frightened kid who'd come in to tidy a wing-surgery and overheard her whole secret fellowship being sold to the Wardens — and who, the second she found a reason to step out, was going to run, straight to whoever held her leash.

She was four metres off. Sefa was flat on a board and couldn't cross them. The girl's eyes flicked, once, to the door.

So Sefa took her name off Brede's lips — she caught the old surgeon's eye, and Brede read her in a heartbeat and breathed a single word, "*Pell*" — and called to her, soft and firm, the voice for a spooked flier on a ledge.

"Pell. Don't. Don't go for that door yet. Look at me." Low and even. "I'm strapped to a board with my wing in pieces and the Wing-Master needs a second pair of steady hands, and yours are steadier than mine right now by a long way. So come here. Hold the lamp for her. That's all I'm asking. Just — come hold the lamp."

Not *I see your pin*. Not *don't you dare warn them*. A wounded woman asking a scared kid for help. A reason to step toward the room instead of out of it.

For one terrible breath the girl was frozen between the door and the table — and then the thing Sefa had gambled on won. A frightened person handed a small honest task instead of an accusation takes the task like a rope thrown in water. Pell's shoulders dropped. She set the tray down — carefully, even now — and crossed the four metres toward the cradle, and lifted the lamp in both shaking hands and held it steady over the opened wing. Close now. Inside reach. The pin plain

at her open collar, rising and falling too fast, a tear hung on her lower lashes she was too scared to blink loose.

“...Steady, girl,” Brede said, softer than Sefa had heard her. “Bit higher with the lamp. Good. That’s good.” Giving the kid a place to put her hands.

Sefa let the lamp settle her, and then spoke under the brazier-crackle, just for the two of them.

“I’m not going to call the guard. I’m not going to take your pin, and Kithrel by the door isn’t going to touch you. You heard everything I said about Vesh and the Stilling and what that fire was, so you already know I’m not angry at a frightened girl holding a lamp.” She let it sit. “I think you’re scared of the right things, Pell. I think you took that pin believing it meant the kind thing — sitting with the dying, easing the hopeless — the way it meant for the Wing-Master here for forty years. And somewhere lately you started hearing them say it about people who *aren’t* dying. And it frightened you. That’s not weakness. That’s your conscience working exactly the way it’s meant to.” The girl’s knuckles whitened on the lamp; the tear fell. “So I’ll ask you one thing, and you can say no, and you’ll still walk out of here on your own feet. Who has your leash, Pell? Who do you report to?”

The name was right there — the girl’s lips parted, a syllable forming, her whole self leaning across the lamplight —

— and Sefa, every nerve bent on reaching her, leaned in too hard. The blanket slid off her forearm. And the lamplight caught the steel.

The hidden knife. Hilt-to-hand along her wrist, bared in the full light right under the girl’s eyes.

She watched it happen in Pell’s face and there was nothing she could do to stop it: every gentle thing she’d said inverted. Not a wounded woman asking for help — a strapped-down Warden who knew her name, knew about the pin, had a blade hidden the whole time, and was *working her*. The lamp, the kindness, *I’m not going to take your pin* — all of it, a trap with teeth. The girl’s heart broke the wrong way.

“You—” Her voice sheared into something thin and terrified. She didn’t name her handler. She didn’t bolt clean. She just came apart, and the lamp left her hands.

It tumbled, flame guttering, straight down toward the tray of spirit-soaked swabs and the edge of the board where the wing lay open.

“*Kithrel—!*”

Sefa didn’t get a word past her name. Kithrel had been a courier before she was a Warden, and a thing falling was the oldest reflex she owned — two strides, and she caught the lamp a handspan above the swabs, folded it into her body, smothered the wick against her glove. A curl of smoke, the stink of singed leather, and no fire. The board, the wing, the swabs: untouched.

The other half — the words for Pell — those weren’t there. Sefa reached for the one true thing that might have caught her and her tongue found nothing, and it didn’t matter, because the girl was long past hearing. She saw the knife. There is no sentence in the world that un-sees a hidden blade. She didn’t run and she didn’t scream — the sound climbing her throat never made it out. She folded. Her legs went, and she slid down the wall to the floor, knees to her chest, both hands over her face, a thin broken keening leaking between her fingers. Undone by her own terror more thoroughly than anything Sefa could have done to her. Contained. The fire out. The surgery quiet but for the sobbing.

And utterly not hers. No name. No turn.

Brede had stopped working. She was staring at the heap of her apprentice, her old face gone grey. “...Pell,” she said, very quietly. “Oh, child.”

Sefa made the call that cost something. She stood down. First the knife — she eased it back out of sight beneath the blanket, slow and obvious, *let her see it disappear*, because the worst thing in this room was a blade and a Warden’s hard face, and she could subtract one of those. Then she went still. She caught Kithrel’s eye and tipped her head at the door — *quiet, watch it, let the girl be* — and gave Brede the

floor, because Brede was the only one who could stand on it. “Wing-Master. She’s yours. I’ll keep still and keep my mouth shut.”

Brede laid a wax-paper swab over the open wing-root, stripped a glove with her teeth, and crossed to the floor. What knelt down by Pell was just an old woman who’d buried too many people. She didn’t reach for the pin. She didn’t say *traitor*. She got down to the girl’s level, both knees on the cold bone, and waited until the sobbing hitched enough that words might fit.

“Pell. Look at my collar. Go on. You took yours for the same reason I took mine. The sitting-up with the dying. The hand held at the end so no one goes into the dark alone. That’s what it meant, child. That’s what you swore. And somewhere this winter they started asking you to swear to something else, and it’s been eating you hollow, and you didn’t have anyone to say it to.” Her voice cracked. “You do now. I never left. Talk to me.”

For a moment it seemed to work. The sobbing eased; Pell’s hands came down a little; she looked at the closed hand at Brede’s throat and up at the wet, earnest eyes, and Sefa saw her *want* to fall into it, want to be the apprentice again.

And then something in her face closed like a shutter.

“...You too,” she whispered. Almost too quiet to hear. “They got you too.” She didn’t mean the Wardens. She meant the world — the great betrayal the Choir promised was everywhere, the proof that everyone who walks out of the quiet is lost to the noise and the cruelty of it. Her own master, kneeling in a Warden’s surgery beside a Warden’s blade-girl — to Pell, in that moment, that was not rescue. It was the last person she trusted proving the sermon right. She pulled her knees back to her chest and went quiet — not calm, closed, wrapped around the pin and the doctrine like they were the only warm thing left.

Brede stayed down a moment longer, a hand hovering near the girl’s shoulder, not quite landing. Then she got up, slowly, and the look she turned on Sefa was the most defeated thing in the room. “...I can set a wing,” she said, low and bitter. “Forty years, I can set any wing in the sky. I never did learn to mend the other thing.”

Sefa gave the order the way a Warden gives the hard ones — quietly, and without pretending it was anything else. “Kithrel. Take her in. Gentle — no irons, she’s a frightened kid, not a brawler. But she’s heard every word of ours, and we don’t get to let that walk out the door.” She turned her head to Brede, because she wouldn’t do it behind her back. “Wing-Master. I’m sorry. She knows the whole of it, and the second she’s loose she’s a danger to the meet, to Esk, to *you* most of all — they’ll know you turned the moment she reports. Taking her in is the only thing that keeps you alive long enough to matter. And you have my word, the one I gave you. No harm. She’s handled as a scared girl who got caught in something. You’ll know where she’s held, and you’ll be let to see her. I’ll stand on that the same as I’d stand on a sword.”

The old surgeon looked at her a long, terrible moment, then down at the heap of her apprentice, then closed her eyes and gave one small, broken nod. “...Aye. You’re right and I hate that you’re right.” Fierce, through the tears: “Take her gentle, courier. And you — keep that word, Rocksquill, or I’ll set your wing crooked after all.”

Kithrel crouched by the girl. “Come on, Pell. Up you come. Nobody’s going to hurt you.” And the worst of it: Pell didn’t fight. She let herself be drawn up by the elbow and turned toward the door, moving like something already gone, still wrapped around the pin, eyes fixed on nothing. At the threshold she didn’t look back at Brede. That was the thing that broke the old woman — not the arrest. The not-looking-back.

“You carry a message better than I give one,” Sefa told Kithrel at the stair-head. “Say it your way.”

Something in the soot-streaked face eased — a courier handed her own reins. “Aye. I’ll tell her: one parcel, fragile, handle soft; the nest’s been kicked over so come before the birds scatter; and there’s a grey hen here laying eggs worth the flight if the fox visits quiet.” The ghost of her old grin. “She’ll have it untangled before I’ve landed.” A last look back. “Don’t let the butcher finish you while I’m out. I’ve gone into one fire for you this week.”

Then she was gone down the stair, the girl moving hollow at her side, out into the morning gales. The surgery settled into quiet — the gulls, the gauze breathing — and Brede fitted the loupe back over her eye, lifted the wax-paper swab off the wing-root, and went back to the slow, expert business of giving Sefa back the sky. “Hold still,” she murmured, gentler than she’d been all morning, the grief gone down into her hands where she knew what to do with it. “This part I can mend.”

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A while passed — enough for Brede to close the wing, bind it in stiff waxed wrappings and a light splint-frame, and have Sefa shifted off the cradle onto a propped recovery cot where she could sit up and look a person in the eye. The wing was a dull throb under the binding now. She couldn’t lift it. But it was hers again, and Brede said it would fly.

She heard Esk before she saw her, playing the cover loud enough for any ear on the stair: “—no, I’ll see her myself, I don’t care if she’s sleeping, one of my Wardens burns a wing off saving half a tenement and I’ll damn well sit at her bedside—” and then she was through the door, big and brisk in company-grey, and shut it with her heel and the volume went out of her like a snuffed lamp.

“...You look like something the Veyl reefs spat back,” she said, and there was no joke under it. “Kithrel found me. Gave me your parcel — she’s in a quiet room with two of my steadiest and a blanket and nobody’s laid a finger on her, before you ask, because Kithrel made *very* sure I knew you’d promised it. We’ll come back to that promise, you and I.”

Then she took proper measure of the old Roak woman by the instrument table — the bloodied apron, the closed-hand pin, the red-rimmed eyes — and the two of them weighed each other a moment, the commander and the wing-master, two people used to being the most dangerous one in any room.

Esk spoke first. “Wing-Master Brede. My Warden says you’re the door into the thing that’s been growing under my city, and that you

opened it of your own will at some cost. She also says there's a clock on us now. So I'll be plain and I'd be grateful if you'd answer plain. The closed hand. How many, how high, and how long before they know the floor's gone out from under them and scatter."

Brede glanced once at Sefa — *is this one safe* — and Sefa gave her the smallest nod. *He's the real one. Tell her.*

It came out flat and grief-worn, and it was worse and smaller than they'd feared, both at once. "The Stillhand's never been large. A few dozen, guild-wide, most of my generation. The *rot* is smaller still." Four names, laid down like instruments on a tray. "Aldous Penmarrow — senior man, respected, and that's the danger of him; he lends the young ones a grey head to hide behind. Yew Castellan, two-and-twenty and certain as only the young and the cruel get. Marrek. The Tasso woman. There'll be one or two more I don't know. I'll write you every name I'm sure of before you leave."

"And above them," Esk said. "You said *how high* like it scared you."

"Because it should scare us both. Vesh ran a feeding-cult under your windlane approach for a *season*. Provisioned it. Grew a scar. And no writ-hand ever came down on him, no inquiry, no guild discipline though there were whispers enough. That doesn't happen to a lone bad surgeon. Someone kept the Wardens off that gallery, and someone in my guild made sure the Pinion Council never *looked*." She said the name like it tasted of rust. "Pinion-Master Halloway Crane. Head of the guild. I can't prove he wears the pin. But every door that should have opened on Vesh, Crane kept shut — and the writs that kept your people off that approach didn't come from any guild. They came from over all our heads."

Esk went very quiet at that. *Over all our heads* meant the Crown. The Spirarchy. The same hand that kept other lids screwed down in this city. Sefa watched her decide not to chase that thread out loud in a surgery, and file it somewhere deep and cold.

"The clock," Esk said instead.

“Pell tends a drop tonight — the third side-mouth, ninth-night provisions. When she doesn’t come, and doesn’t come home, they’ll know by the small hours.” Brede’s voice caught on the girl’s name. “And there’s worse. With Vesh dead, the one holding the rot together now isn’t Penmarrow or any of the loud ones. It’s the keeper. Wren Sallowmend.” She looked at Sefa. “Vesh’s elder sister. Colder than him and twice as organised. Vesh was the *belief*. Wren is the *hands*. She was in that gallery and she walked out of it. She’s the one you actually have to catch — and the one who’ll smell this first.”

Esk stood a moment, soot and lamplight, doing the commander’s arithmetic. Then she turned to the cot. “Rocksquill. You can’t fly and you can’t fight, so you’ll not be on tonight’s wing, and don’t argue it. But you’ve got the one thing I’m short of and can’t make in an afternoon. You’ve got the only person who’s been inside the rot and might still be reachable, sitting in a quiet room three streets over. Pell knows the names I don’t. The drops, the faces, where Wren roosts.” Her eyes held Sefa’s, level and unsentimental. “And you swore that girl wouldn’t be squeezed. So talk to me about your promise. Because in about six hours I have to take a keeper who burns rooms full of people, and the kid you vouched for is the fastest road to her. I’ll keep your word if you tell me to. I’d just like you to look me in the eye when you tie my hands.”

And Sefa felt the whole ugly war of it, in the space of Esk’s waiting.

The rage came up first, and it came up strong — Wren Sallowmend’s face she’d never seen clear through the smoke, the casks, the families on the mats, the fledgling Brede couldn’t save, a voice in her that sounded like the fire itself. *She’ll do it again, to a hundred more, and you’ll hobble the one wing that can catch her for a promise to a kid who spat in your face? Stop the quiet. Whatever it takes.* It was loud. It very nearly had her.

And then the other thing held. Quieter. Older. The thing that had made her a Warden instead of just a sharp pair of wings. *A Warden’s word is the one thing the Stillhand can’t counterfeit. The day you torture*

a frightened girl for the greater good, you haven't beaten the closed hand. You've joined it, in better colours.

She looked Esk in the eye, the way she'd been asked, and tied her hands.

"Keep my word, Commander. No squeezing. Pell stays a scared kid in a warm room, untouched, exactly like I swore to the woman giving you four names she'll hang for. If we catch Wren by breaking faith with the first person who trusted us out of that fellowship, then the next one never comes out, and the one after that. The code's not a luxury we spend when it's expensive. It's the recruiting tool. Brede turned because a Warden was straight with her. Keep me straight." She let a breath go, and offered the road instead of the wall. "And we don't need her. Pell tends the third side-mouth drop tonight — and Pell's in your warm room. So the drop goes untended, and someone comes to find out why. You don't squeeze the girl, ser. You sit on her route and you let Wren walk to you."

Esk held her eye through all of it. Then, slowly, something settled in her face, and it wasn't disappointment. It was the look she'd given on the stair the night she wouldn't let Sefa carry the fire. "...Aye," she said quietly. "That's the right answer and the harder one, and I wanted to be sure you knew it was both before I let you give it." She straightened, and the commander came back into her voice. "The drop, then. Brede's names tonight, quiet and simultaneous. Eyes on Crane, no hands. And my best wing sitting on that third side-mouth in the dark, waiting for a keeper who thinks she's coming to scold an apprentice." A grim flicker. "She'll come herself. The organised ones always check the thing that went wrong with their own eyes."

She gave the wing-master a short nod that had a great deal in it, and went to the door, and put the cover back on like a coat. The volume came up. "—rest, that's an order, I'll have no heroics out of you for a fortnight—" and then she was gone, down into the morning and the long day of quiet arrangements that would end after dark in a bone-mouth that smelled of nothing.

Sefa lay back on the cot. She couldn't fly. She couldn't fight. She'd built the whole of the night that was coming and she'd not see a moment of it, and somewhere across the city a girl who should have been an ally was wrapped around a pin in a warm room, hating her.

Brede came and sat by her without being asked, an old surgeon with nothing left to mend for the moment, and the two of them watched the gauze breathe in the windows and the light go long and gold across the lime-washed bone, and neither of them said the third name out loud.

"You did a clean thing in a filthy week," Brede said at last.

"Doesn't feel clean."

"No," the Wing-Master said. "The clean ones never do."